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Infusing the Cultural Space of Ghirlandaio's Renaissance Paintings into 50's Post-War Modernist Architecture

The cultural space of Renaissance paintings, such as those of Domenico Ghirlandaio, and the 50's post-war modernist architecture in Germany, represent two distinct and contrasting expressions of art and design from two different eras.

Renaissance paintings, such as those of Ghirlandaio, were characterized by their focus on religious themes, classical motifs, and an emphasis on harmony, balance, and proportion. Ghirlandaio, who was active in Florence during the 15th century, was known for his elegant and sophisticated depictions of religious scenes and portraits. His works, like many of his contemporaries, were heavily influenced by the classical ideals of beauty and harmony, as well as a keen interest in naturalism and scientific observation.

On the other hand, post-war modernist architecture in Germany, was characterized by its clean lines, minimalist forms, and a focus on functionality. Architects such as Mies van der Rohe and Walter Gropius, who were part of the Bauhaus movement, aimed to create a new architectural style that would reflect the social and technological changes of the time. The rules laid out for Post-war Modernism rejected the ornate and decorative forms of the past and instead focused on creating buildings that were simple, efficient, and technologically advanced. The 50s post-war modernism in Frankfurt am Main had a significant impact on the city's cultural, social, economic, architectural, and urban landscape. The city saw a massive rebuilding effort that resulted in the construction of numerous modernist buildings, including the iconic Frankfurt School of Finance & Management. The new architecture helped to rejuvenate the city's image, attracted new businesses and investment, and led to the growth of Frankfurt as a major center of finance, trade, and culture.

At the office of Jourdan Müller Steinhauser Architects, the architect expressed fascination with Renaissance paintings by Ghirlandaio for a project. He was convinced that the colors used to express space in these paintings would pair well with the interiors of Landwirtschaftliche Rentenbank (LRB) in Frankfurt. LRB, a 1950s Post-War modernist building, is currently undergoing both renovation and extension. The original 7-story structure will be expanded to 11 stories, and the entire core is set to be re-planned and refurbished.

In this particular context, the team formulated a perspective on the Interior-architecture of the project. This perspective is an amalgamation of diverse ideas and research that have been amassed through several years of meticulous planning, rigorous analysis, and a focus on the spatial characteristics that are best suited for this project. Throughout this process, a series of implicit guidelines have emerged that are inherently tailored to the unique requirements of this project.

1. The Architectural Skin & The Flying Roof, seminal components of this Post-War Modernist Building in the 1950s, embody an approach that prioritizes the seamless integration of exterior and interior spaces. In this regard, the utilization of White-Bronze for Window Frames, Natural Stones for Parapets, and basic Whites for Columns serve as a means of bringing the exterior into the interior in a manner that aligns with the principles of the architectural style. This governing rule is meticulously upheld, extending from the Entrance Foyer to the corridors, where the Language of Natural Stones, Glass, and White+Bronze frames merge with the interior space and ultimately meld with the terrace area featuring the Flying Roof, perched atop the newly constructed 11th floor.

As a monumental figure amidst a sea of comparable grandeur, The Architectural Skin and The Flying Roof offer an object of curiosity that is enriched by their relation to the primary viewing angles of the project: from the exterior onto the interior. The interiors, or the core Cultural Element, serve as the focal point for the Architectural Skin and The Flying Roof, which maintain their integrity as dynamic yet cohesive units that inspire awe and wonder in equal measure.

2. The Cultural Element (the Interiors) lies at the core of the project, and draws inspiration from a specific set of Renaissance Paintings. The language, form, proportion, and, crucially, the rich and vibrant colour palette that characterizes these paintings constitute the basis of the Cultural Element that shapes the interior spaces of our project. This carefully selected colour palette has been tailored to the project's interiors with a keen vision of facilitating a profound cultural exchange.

The Architectural Skin serves as the canvas that contains and conveys this message, while the Colour Palette manifests in various forms such as pixels, stripes, surfaces, volumes, and objects that form the essential elements of the Painted Spaces. These elements are translated into various design features, including frames, wall panels, furniture pieces, railings, light fixtures, artwork, and artifacts. The seamless integration of these design features into the overall architectural scheme creates a harmonious environment in which every space assumes the quality of a scene from the series of paintings, bringing the Cultural Element to life in a vivid and meaningful way.

3. Space of the Paintings

3.1. The Common Area: Within the formal space of the painting, the strokes that bring forth the Common Area are the Five Stones, Single Tone Furniture Pieces, and Striped Artwork. The base form of the Painting echoes a Repeated/Mirrored Façade, Multiple Levels of Spaces, and a horizon of Striped Panelling on the uppermost level.

3.2. **The Executive Area:** The Vibrant Sculptural Central Element, adorned with two contrasting colors, serves as the focal point of the Executive Area. Repeated Elements and Vibrant Foreground Objects contribute to the dynamic atmosphere. Frames and Solid Outlines frame the walls and ceiling, while everyday secular details are employed as accessories.

3.3. **The Guest Area:** A bold use of perspective/vision line, classical bordered elements, reliefs, and the strong horizontal line of the wall below them establish a link between the formal and informal meeting spaces. The color schemes applied create a captivating clarity of the Spaces.

4. **Ghirlandaio's Painted Spaces :** Ghirlandaio, a master painter of the Renaissance era, was renowned for his ability to create painted spaces that were both lifelike and otherworldly. He incorporated architectural elements, such as columns, arches, and ornate frames, to convey a sense of depth and dimensionality in his works. The use of light and shadow, along with his meticulous attention to detail and mastery of anatomy, endowed his paintings with a naturalistic quality highly valued during the Renaissance. Ghirlandaio's painted spaces were not merely depictions of the physical world but also conveyed allegorical and symbolic representations of the religious and moral themes he sought to convey.

4.1. Painting 1:

"Expulsion of Joachim from the Temple" uses architectural elements to convey both realistic and symbolic space. The temple's facade, with its columns, arches, and ornate frieze, creates a sense of depth and perspective and represents the spiritual realm and moral teachings of the church. The figures in the foreground are arranged in a triangular formation, and the use of light and shadow adds to the sense of space. The painting also includes a background that references Brunelleschi's design for the Spedale degli Innocenti, and two palaces that mirror the lines of the temple. Ghirlandaio's attention to detail in incorporating the city's urban fabric emphasizes the significance of place and context in the creation of architectural space.



4.2. Painting 2:

In "Birth of Saint John the Baptist", Ghirlandaio's use of architectural elements and colors creates a realistic and symbolic sense of space. The birth chamber, with its vaulted ceiling, columns, and moldings, contributes to the sense of depth and perspective. The triangular formation of the figures and use of perspective adds to the sense of space. The architectural space represents the sanctity and significance of the event. The use of contrasting complementary colors contributes to the clarity that characterizes Ghirlandaio's work. The attention to detail in the room lends a sense of grandeur to the scene. Overall, Ghirlandaio's use of architectural elements, colors, and attention to detail create a captivating and realistic depiction of the scene.



4.3. Painting 3:

Ghirlandaio's "Visitation" painting uses architectural space to create depth and hierarchy within the composition, with a traditional triangular arrangement of figures. The spacious room with a vaulted ceiling and decorated walls adds to the sense of grandeur and importance of the visitation, while linear perspective draws the viewer's focus to the central figures. The right wall of the Tornabuoni Chapel uses converging lines of perspective to convey spatial depth, and a paved road and servant figure connect the painting to the story of Saint John the Baptist on the opposite wall. On the left side of the painting, there is a group of women that is a variation of a single type, which is typical of Ghirlandaio's work.



Despite the differences in their aesthetics and goals, both Renaissance paintings and post-war modernist architecture played a crucial role in shaping the cultural space of their respective eras. Renaissance paintings, with their emphasis on harmony and balance, reflected the cultural ideals of the Renaissance and helped to establish a new standard for beauty and artistic expression. Similarly, post-war modernist architecture in Germany helped to reshape the cultural landscape of the country and set a new standard for architecture that would be influential for decades to come.

The cultural space of Ghirlandaio's Renaissance paintings and 50's post-war modernist architecture in Germany represent two distinct and contrasting expressions of art and design. Despite their differences, both played a significant role in shaping the cultural landscape of their respective eras and continue to influence art and architecture today.

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